

Keep Christmas in Your Heart Daily.

The Observant Message of El Monte Commandery No. 2, KT

12 December, 2022

Sir Knights, Companions, Brethren and Honoured Guests,

Charles Dickens wrote in his timeless classic, 'A Christmas Carol': "For it is good to be children sometimes, and never better than at Christmas, when its mighty Founder was a child himself." – Charles Dickens, A Christmas Carol. December 19, 1843.

How true it is, that we stand on the precipice of the commemoration of the Blessed birth of Emmanuel, the Christ Child that the world would know as Yeshua bin Yosef, or Jesus, son of Joseph (and Mary) of Nazareth. In this time of joy, of miracles, and of peace on Earth, we have the blessing of hindsight, and the fortune of opportunity.

As Freemasons, we travel ever in search of light. As Apprentices, we are encouraged to build our spiritual life, agreeable to the designs and rules laid down within that Volume of Sacred Law; which is, at once, the revealed will of G-d; and our moral and Masonic Trestleboard. Herein, we read the words of Gabriel, Archangel of Heaven, where he comforts the shepherds by saying, "Fear not...For unto you is born this day ... Christ the Lord." (Luke 2:8-14 KJV).

As parents, sons, and Brothers we are the shepherds - called upon to elevate our households and communities to G-d; as Sir Knights we must keep in mind the words of Christ Jesus, when he said, "... I am the Light of the world: he that follows me shall not walk in darkness, but shall have the light of life."

It is this bright and shining light we must seek. Sir Knights "...Templary is founded upon ...the practice of the Christian virtues. The world has never witnessed a more unselfish service for G-d and humanity than that which was exemplified by ...intrepid Crusaders. "

"...The principles upon which the orders [of the Commandery]... are founded are expressed in the ...extols of the doctrine of human brotherhood and benevolence toward all mankind. It commends the reign of peace and glorifies the search for Divine Truth...virtues taught by the highest ideals of the Christian faith."

As the character Jacob Marley exclaims - in the Charles Dickens' classic: 'A Christmas Carol', "Mankind was my business. The common welfare was my business; charity, mercy, forbearance, and benevolence, were, all, my business." So too, must we make the charity taught in the Fellow Craft degree our 'business' and 'benevolence' within our daily life.

The miracle of the birth of the King of Kings: the Prince of Peace – was that the Word became Flesh – Love and its Champion was borne in Grace and gifted to the world. There is no more supreme benevolence; no higher charity; no greater mercy than Love. "For G-d IS Love;" and he that knows Love, knows G-d.

The very purpose of the Ministry of Christ would be to bring the Message of Love, Charity and Virtue to all who have ears who would listen. The Divine Truth was handed to us by the highest authority who taught the greatest ideals of our Christian faith. In His teachings, Christ gave us the 'Greatest Commandments' of Love; the ability to forgive; to act in the discipline of the Golden Rule; to avoid prejudice and judgement; to walk away from

the wages of sin, to seek salvation and eternal life. Jesus called every shepherd and Son of Light to be humble; to be a servant; to be His Disciple; and to abide by His New Commandment: “to Love one another...” As Christ Loves each and every one of us. This Grace and Love is the Miracle we celebrate at Christmas.

As Fred (Ebenezer’s Nephew) so eloquently states: “There are many things from which I might have derived good, by which I have not profited, I dare say,’ returned the nephew. ‘Christmas among the rest. But I am sure I have always thought of Christmas time, when it has come round—apart from the veneration due to its sacred name and origin, if anything belonging to it can be apart from that—as a good time; a kind, forgiving, charitable, pleasant time; the only time I know of, in the long calendar of the year, when men and women seem by one consent to open their shut-up hearts freely, and to think of people below them as if they really were fellow-passengers to the grave, and not another race of creatures bound on other journeys. And therefore, uncle, though it has never put a scrap of gold or silver in my pocket, I believe that it has done me good, and will do me good; and I say, G-d bless it!’”

Fred reveals an unfortunate fact. Life will return to a hurried state. Society will numb themselves to the plights and troubles of the community. Men and women will once again shut their hearts to the ability to compassionate the miseries of others; ignoring the opportunity to sympathize with the misfortunes of our fellow creatures; and therefore, refuse to seek the chance to sooth the discomforts of trouble minds. This is the sad fate of man.

Thank G-d Almighty, that we do not have to be plagued by the folly Fred forewarns. Each of us can choose to keep the miracle of Christmas alive. We can choose to remember that the Lord of Lords was born to a poor family. That Mary, pregnant with Christ, travelled on a donkey; while Joseph guided on foot throughout that immense journey. – That they travelled over 90 miles from Nazareth to the City of David, only to discover there were no open doors, no room at any inn. We can hold on to the truth that Christ was born in a stable fashioned from a cave, adjacent to the inn that refused them a room; laid in a manger where He drew the first moments of His life alongside livestock. From these humble beginnings came the Savior of mankind.

He could have been born into a life of comfort and privilege; But G-d’s love was too great. Knowing that it was the whole of humanity that greatly needed this miracle, “His only begotten Son” was chosen to embrace the whole human experience; and from the depths of misfortunes was born the King of Kings.

G-d chose. Knowing His creations, Loving Mankind, G-d chose Love and Charity. G-d chose to bless the whole of humanity. This miracle alone should reside in our heart; and guide our thoughts, words, deeds, and actions every day of the year. Christmas can, and should be each and every day, in the household of the faithful.

So go and “Reflect upon your present blessings—of which every man has many—not on your past misfortunes, of which all men have some.” As Sir Knight Wilber Marion Brucker, Most Eminent Past Grand Master [of the Grand Encampment of Knights Templar USA] wrote: “...Let no Knight Templar underestimate the task that lies ahead nor shrink from playing his part.” and remember that “...The righteous and benevolent influence of Templars and of our Commanderies is needed everywhere.”

“...In this spirit, we summon every officer and Sir Knight to put on the whole armor of G-d as we march forth into this new ...[day].”

Keep Christmas alive today, tomorrow and every day. Be that Soldier of Christ who embraces the teachings of Divine Truth and lives according to the Light of the World.

Finally, I challenge each of us to “Love one another” as Christ Commanded, and to embrace the mantra of Ebenezer Scrooge who said:

“I will honour Christmas in my heart, and try to keep it all the year. I will live in the Past, the Present, and the Future. The Spirits of all Three shall strive within me. I will not shut out the lessons that they teach!” – Ebenezer Scrooge.

Yours in Knightly Courtesy,



Sir Knight William E. McCraw
Generalissimo

El Monte Commandery No. 2, KT of Utah

Verses in Scripture:

- Luke 2:8-14 (KJV)
- 1 John 4:7-11 (KJV)
- Matthew 22:37-40 (KJV)
- Matthew 7:1-6 (KJV)
- Matthew 7:12 (KJV)
- John 8: 10-11 (KJV)
- Matthew 23:11-12 (KJV)
- Romans 6:23 (KJV)
- John 8: 12 (KJV)
- John 13: 31-35 (KJV)
- John 3:16-21 (KJV)

Charles Dickens Quotes:

“‘Business!’ cried the Ghost, wringing its hands again. ‘Mankind was my business. The common welfare was my business; charity, mercy, forbearance, and benevolence, were, all, my business. The dealings of my trade were but a drop of water in the comprehensive ocean of my business!’” – Charles Dickens, A Christmas Carol. December 19, 1843.

“Reflect upon your present blessings—of which every man has many—not on your past misfortunes, of which all men have some.” – Charles Dickens, A Christmas Dinner. Sketches by Boz. 1835. P. 220

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Quotes from Charting The Course:

“...Templary is founded upon ...the practice of the Christian virtues. The world has never witnessed any more unselfish service for G-d and humanity than that which was exemplified by ...intrepid Crusaders. Today's Templars are likewise committed to tasks of exalted usefulness, just as were their illustrious forebears many centuries ago.” - Charting The Course by Sir Knight Wilber Marion Brucker, Most Eminent Past Grand Master, Knights Templar, U.S.A., and published February 15, 1965. John L. Palmer, References: Knight Templar Magazine, 2015, February, March, April, May and June.

“...The principles upon which the orders of Knighthood are founded are expressed in ritual and symbolism and are founded upon the teachings of the Christian religion. Templary is based upon...extols the doctrine of human brotherhood and benevolence toward all mankind. It commends the reign of peace and glorifies the search for Divine Truth. It vows to... [defend the].. innocent; destitute widows, helpless orphans, and the... [virtues taught by the highest ideals of the Christian faith.] It... magnifies freedom under law and Constitutional government. It stands unswervingly for good morals and right living by each Knight Templar as an example of good citizenship in every community. Each Knight Templar has voluntarily professed the fatherhood of G-d, the brotherhood of man, and love of country. “- Charting The Course by Sir Knight Wilber Marion Brucker, Most Eminent Past Grand Master, Knights Templar, U.S.A., and published February 15, 1965. John L. Palmer, References: Knight Templar Magazine, 2015, February, March, April, May and June.

“...Let no Knight Templar underestimate the task that lies ahead nor shrink from playing his part... Let each of us recognize that it will be an uphill battle with worldly strife along the way. This should only add zest to acceptance of the challenge by the ...[humble Soldier of Christ].” - Charting The Course by Sir Knight Wilber Marion Brucker, Most Eminent Past Grand Master, Knights Templar, U.S.A., and published February 15, 1965. John L. Palmer, References: Knight Templar Magazine, 2015, February, March, April, May and June.

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“...The righteous and benevolent influence of Templars and of our Commanderies is needed everywhere. Our influence in the form of our programs and projects is limited only by the devotion and resources of our members.” - Charting The Course by Sir Knight Wilber Marion Brucker, Most Eminent Past Grand Master, Knights Templar, U.S.A., and published February 15, 1965. John L. Palmer, References: Knight Templar Magazine, 2015, February, March, April, May and June.